



Trench design

Trenches were cut in zig-zag patterns rather than straight lines. This meant that if any enemy attackers got inside they could not shoot along the entire length of the trench.

Defensive lines

The Allied attack at Messines took place along a 9¾-mile (16-km) front, but the heaviest fighting was at the long, low hill known as Messines Ridge. Today, the area is mostly farmland—as it was before the war—but in some places landowners have allowed archaeologists to dig up the site. This replica trench has been built at a nearby site.

Support structure

Trench walls were made of earth and sometimes collapsed. They were strengthened with wooden planks, wicker branches, or corrugated iron.

Duckboards

Trench floors were lined with wooden slats called duckboards that helped keep soldiers' feet dry. Troops who stood in mud and water too long suffered from a rotting condition called trench foot.

Extra firepower

The German trench systems included concrete "pillboxes" with machine guns on top to fire on enemy attacks. They were usually square, with a slit at the front for defenders to fire from.

